

fluke, as she followed it up with a decisive 6-1, 6-4 victory over Australian Open champion Keys.

Currently No. 15 in the live (2025) rankings, Tauson plays intimidating first-strike tennis on both serve and when returning second serves. In her case, the best defence is an excellent offence because her biggest weakness is her below-average movement.

"She can rocket-fire her forehand, but it can go off for her when she's rushed," said Petkovic. As women's tennis gets faster and faster, how fast Tauson runs will determine her success both offensively and defensively. With a decent draw, she'll make the quarterfinals.

Coco Gauff — Gauff was tabbed for future stardom ever since she became the youngest girls' finalist in U.S. Open history as a 13-year-old prodigy in 2017. She credits her girlhood idols, Serena and Venus Williams — whose fearlessness and tenacity she admired — for taking up the sport. Ironically, in her Grand Slam debut, Gauff upset Venus in the 2019 Wimbledon first round.

Amazingly, the veteran returned to the pro tour this summer at age 45 after a 16-month absence, and they could conceivably meet again.

Gauff's road towards the top has been more uneven than her current No. 2 ranking suggests. Although she upset Sabalenka in come-from-behind, three-set finals to capture the 2023 U.S. Open and 2025 French Open, all too often she has self-destructed, committing a rash of confidence-sapping double faults and wild unforced forehand errors. During her latest slump following Roland Garros, Gauff lost in the first round at Berlin and Wimbledon, and in the third round at Montreal to rookie Mboko, an 18-year-old Canadian wild card, 6-1, 6-4. Her double fault woes continued as she made 23 against Danielle Collins, 14 against Veronika Kudermetova in three-set wins, and five more among her 24 unforced errors against Mboko.

Looking at the bright side of her rollercoaster season, *Tennis Channel* analyst Nicolas Pereira pointed to

her 9-1 record in three-set matches, saying, "She does it with her wheels, and she does it with her heart." But her splendid backhand, strong first serve, exceptional mobility, and fighting spirit can only take her so far if she keeps beating herself.

Which Gauff will show up at Flushing Meadows? Only the best version of herself stands a chance of making the semis this year.

Mirra Andreeva — When the self-confident, 18-year-old Russian is good, she's really, really good. Mirra whipped Swiatek, former Wimbledon champions Rybakina and Marketa Vondrousova, and Tauson to win Dubai in February. That made Andreeva, then 17, the youngest 1000 champion since Caroline Wozniacki in 2009.

Andreeva's litany of distinguished victims only grew at Indian Wells, where she claimed her second WTA 1000 title. She swept past Tauson, Rybakina, and Svitolina in straight sets to reach the semis. Then the 5'10" athlete showcased her all-court



Strength and grace: Currently No. 15 in the live rankings, Clara Tauson plays intimidating first-strike tennis on both serve and when returning second serves. REUTERS

game — serves up to 120 mph and baseline versatility — to edge No. 2 Swiatek 7-6(1), 1-6, 6-3 and No. 1 Sabalenka 2-6, 6-4, 6-3. Fun to watch on court, the multilingual prodigy is even funnier during interviews, with a clever repartee that belies her age.

Tracy Austin, a teen queen who captured two U.S. Opens before injuries derailed her brilliant career, said, "Her forehand is so much improved. Her incredible shot is a forehand slice on the run. To have Conchita Martinez [as her coach] is an absolute genius. She watched a motivational video from LeBron James, who advised, 'If you can't be 100 per cent physically, you have a choice to be 100 per cent mentally.' She'll win Grand Slams for sure."

The ambitious Andreeva, ranked